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## Overkill: Why Excess and Conflict are both Sexy and Sacred

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### Abstract

In popular understandings, both excess and conflict are understood as compelling, even 'sexy'. Drawing from the perspectives of feminist theory, history, and theology, I consider the ways that patriarchal cultures eroticize possession, domination, and taboo violation, leading to this popular apprehension. I critique some of the ways that patriarchal conceptions of sex and God, both founded in a gendered conception of power as domination, intersect to influence significantly and foment harms including environmental devastation.

*Overkill*: 1. Nuclear destructive capacity exceeding the amount needed to destroy an enemy. 2. Any greatly excessive action or response.

—*American Heritage Dictionary*

*The Incredible Mr. MX*: Take a long look at the real weapon of the '80s... See his 16 ½ inch missile.

—Porn film, 1988

*I knew my God was bigger than his god.*

—Lt. Gen. William G. 'Jerry' Boykin, discussing his battle against a Muslim 'warlord' in Somalia (in Cooper 2003).

Tell me that you don't have to fuck yourself on

The reactor core of an intense meltdown

To show your importance

Tell me that you have no desire

To be the first one to fuck

Into the fission of a fusion

Of a fucking holocaust (Cortez 1984: 109).

The poet Jayne Cortez takes up a language of deliberate extremity in order to address what functions as a kind of open secret in our culture—the (con)fusion of sex with violence, pleasure with danger, and bigger with better all the way up to and including nuclear holocaust.

During one of the plenary sessions at the Inaugural Conference of the International Society for the Study of Religion, Nature, and Culture, Nina Witoszek-Fitzpatrick asked listeners to consider why the essential environmental value of sustainability did not provide the kind of gripping cultural narrative provided by tales of excess. She wondered quite specifically why excess seems so much ‘sexier’ than sustainability. Marc Bekoff subsequently remarked that conflict too was understood as especially compelling, as ‘sexier’ than peace.

The dangers of excess and war are key factors to any understanding of environmentalism. A practice of excess intrinsically denies reciprocity, the need for a community to give back to, and to respect the limits of, the ecosystem. And, however much a culture loves and supports its men in uniform, critics like Joni Seagar contend that militaries ‘are the biggest threat to the environmental welfare of the planet’ (1993: 15).

Excess and war, moreover, are strangely linked, as the dual meanings of *overkill* suggest. Seeking to understand the sexual frisson of overkill in both of these forms leads to a consideration of why weapons are phallic and targets ‘virgin’, why getting and spending, along with domination and taboo violation, are so often experienced as erotic, and, concomitantly, how and why sex is defined and practiced as possession, control, and transgression. To understand, we need to think about the ways that sexuality and gender are constructed and experienced in the service of power politics, including those that underlie much environmental destruction.

But before turning directly to this task, it is necessary to introduce a companion theme. In 1964, Rachel Carson warned that ‘the modern world worships the gods of speed and quantity, and of the quick and easy profit, and out of this idolatry monstrous evils have arisen’ (1998: 194). Practices of economic excess, Carson implies, are not only sexy but also *sacred*.

So too are experiences of power, which, when it is defined as domination, becomes something that many only ever want more of. Consider this chilling testimony from a Vietnam Veteran recalling his experiences ‘in the field’:

I had a sense of power. A sense of destruction...in the Nam you realized you had the power to take a life. You had the power to rape a woman and nobody could say nothing to you. That godlike feeling you had was in the

field. It was like I was god. I could take a life. I could screw a woman (Baker 1982: 152).

This enactment of power as destruction and perception of godliness as next to rape and murder is extreme, but is it completely unfamiliar? Similar sexual violence permeates our popular culture, particularly in narratives (both factual and fictional) of serial sex killers, who often are cast in heroic and even god-like molds (Caputi 2004b).

There are many, and various, ways to seek to understand such phenomena—biologically, psychologically, sociologically, historically, spiritually, and even archetypally (Hillman 2004). My approach is from a critical and feminist perspective. Rape and other forms of sexual violence during war and otherwise are not universal to human cultures (Sanday 1997). Arguably, such behaviors and perceptions are characteristic not only of the extremities of wartime, but also of everyday life in patriarchal cultures, those where male dominance over women and children is institutionalized in the family and in society in general (Lerner 1986: 239). In such societies, understandings of both power and sex are influenced not only by the systemic unequal relations between men and women, but also by a conceptualization of God as supreme, purely male, transcendent, and omnipotent (Daly 1973). Certainly, I do not mean to suggest that there are no competing sacred narratives (God as Goddess or God/dess, as Sex, Change, Love, Mystery, and/or Multiplicity, not God as singular Omnipotent male), or sexual ones (sex as God/dess, sex as a way of knowledge, sex as communion, sex as mutual invitation, not conquest).<sup>1</sup> These deserve far more elaboration, but in this essay, my primary intent is to draw from the perspectives of feminist theory, history, and theology to critique those common patriarchal conceptions of sex and God and the ways that these are founded in power as domination. In so doing, I will consider some of the ways that these intersect to influence significantly and foment harms including environmental devastation.

### *Possession: Girls, Girls, Girls*

*See, I learned at a very early age what is the coin of this realm. Women! You can buy anything with beautiful women.*

—David, ‘the second greatest pimp in New York’  
(in Sheehy 1973: 170).

1. I trace some of these alternative understandings of sex and God, from ancient times through the present, in ‘Sexuality and Green Consciousness’ (Caputi 2005).

*You were as much his as I was... We were just his, to do with as he pleased, like the pond or the houses or the hogs or the crops.*

—One sister talking to another about their incestuous father  
(Smiley 1991: 191)

Women themselves became a resource, acquired by men much as the land was acquired by men (Lerner 1986: 212).

Questions of sex, gender, power, and possession—intimate as well as ultimate—are at the heart of feminist inquiry about men's sexual violence against women and the ways that such violence is related to abuses of oppressed peoples, the Earth, elements, and creatures. Some researchers tell us that there is a biological basis for men's greater propensity for violence, a violence which, as one of them puts it, is so overwhelmingly ubiquitous that it is 'the very ocean in which we swim' (Barash 2002). Or drown, I might add. Many of us, though, tend to doubt—not the ubiquity, but the inevitability. Even if there is some kind of biological basis, much of the male violence that we know and fear may be a *distortion* of male biological tendencies, wrought by the influence of patriarchal cultures.<sup>2</sup> Or perhaps there is no real biological base at all. James Gilligan (1996) rejects any biological causation and finds the etiology of male violence in civilization's codes of honor and shame and concomitant definitions of women as 'sex objects' and men as 'violence objects'. Gilligan and other feminist thinkers contend that sexual violence is ubiquitous not because it is genetically or hormonally ordained, but because it functions as a form of social control, enforcing top-down power relations—among men as well as between men and women.

In patriarchies, men and women exist in hierarchical relation, with man as the subject, woman as 'the other' (de Beauvoir 1993 [1953]), men on top and women below (though with significant variations due to unequalizing social factors like race, class, and caste). Furthermore, men and women are seen as the only appropriate sexual partners. As such, hierarchy itself takes on a sexual charge and a particular style of sexuality becomes a way of ritually establishing dominance (Millett 1970; Dworkin 1987). This kind of eroticized masculine domination and feminine submission is the agenda behind all the conventional requirements that men be taller, older, richer, and more socially powerful, and that women be smaller, younger, better looking, less knowledgeable, and so on. It also is unmistakably revealed in obscene words like *fuck*, and equivalents like

2. For example, James Hillman (1995: 126) suggests that sexual harassment is a distortion, induced by Puritanism, of the sexual display characterizing all animals, including human animals.

*screw, nail, slice, bang*, which mean not only to have sex with, but also to flaunt one's power over, to disrespect, even to grievously injure.

Patriarchy, though widespread, is not inevitable, and many human cultures—for example, many Native American cultures—never developed it (Allen 1986), nor did they institute individual ownership of land with an economy based in capital (Cronon 1983: 78). Although she finds no evidence for original 'matriarchies', the historian Gerda Lerner (1986) understands patriarchy as a historical phenomenon. Lerner focuses her research on the ways that patriarchal organization advanced in Western civilization, beginning in the third and second millennia BCE. She locates its beginnings in men's enslavement of women from conquered groups. 'It was only after men had learned how to enslave the women of groups who could be defined as strangers, that they learned how to enslave men' (1986: 213). And for women, slavery had a different meaning than it did for men. While men could be, and were, sexually used and abused by both masters and mistresses, this was not the rule. 'For women, sexual exploitation marked the very definition of enslavement' (1986: 89). The commodified sexual and reproductive female body, her 'private parts' if you will—in slavery, in bride price, in prostitution—thus became the first form of wealth-producing and private property.

Even today, through the persistent sexual double standard as well as institutions like traditional romance and marriage, advertising, pornography, and prostitution, women and men are taught to value female sexuality as currency and resource, and to view women as sexual objects. Of course, women are *not* things and have always acted, felt, moved, resisted, or cooperated with patriarchy, and, all the while, influenced history. Nonetheless, it is easy to forget these influences, for throughout our popular culture, women are commonly represented as equivalent to, or indistinguishable from, objects—motorcycles, cars, tables, bottles of beer, something for men to own, drive, consume, and ultimately discard. With women as the paradigmatic symbolic object of possession, possession itself takes on a sexual charge.

This foundational possession/commodification of women may well also have provided the model for something at the core of environmental degradation—the commodification of land, turning it from something numinous, a manifestation of the world soul, even something divine, into some thing, an object to be surveyed and owned. Property (bodies and land) continues to provide the basis of wealth and, of course, excess. Thomas Berry rightly reminds us that the Universe is and must be recognized and experienced as: 'A communion of subjects, not a collection of objects' (2004: 492). But this will prove to be impossible if our culture

remains one that defines women as sexual and reproductive others/objects, a form of collectibles.

*Domination: When Fascism is Sexy*

Fascism—I hate to say it, but it's sexy. The style expresses the idea of taking and then relinquishing control (Ned Cramer, in La Perla 2000).

The remarks of Ned Cramer, a senior editor at *Architecture Magazine*, about the sexiness of fascism are rather disingenuous. In fascism, someone takes control, to be sure, but the controller does not, in turn, relinquish power. Rather, those on top force those on the bottom to yield and the force itself (as well as the subordinate's humiliation, defilement, and violation) is experienced as sexual. When fascism, however covertly, is the touchstone of 'sexiness', equality, along with sustainability and peace, becomes bland and boring, a veritable 'turn-off'.

A fascist understanding of sexuality was everywhere in evidence in the notorious photos documenting sexual torture by US military personnel of Iraqi prisoners at Abu Ghraib prison in 2003.<sup>3</sup> These pictures, a form of trophy shot as well as amateur porn, were taken by the US military personnel, both male and female, inadvertently documenting how they sexually abused and demeaned Iraqi male prisoners by putting them in the feminine 'object' position (e.g. by having panties placed on their heads, by being stripped, and by being placed in homoerotic and sexually inviting postures). Both the male and female abusers assumed the masculine position of dominator, while the male prisoners were degraded by being identified as 'women', forced into the subordinated feminine role and then treated in much the same ways that women generically are treated in pornographic representations, both mainstream and everyday.<sup>4</sup>

3. Numerous incidents of abuse and torture of prisoners by US military personnel occurred at Abu Ghraib prison in Iraq throughout 2003. The tormentors took photos of the abuse and some of these were distributed in Iraq and back to friends in the US. Although, reportedly, women were also raped and sexually humiliated, no photos have been released of this, only photos of abuse of male prisoners. The US Army began an investigation in January 2004 and graphic photos and information were released to the public in April 2004. As of this writing, a number of lower-level military personnel have been convicted for crimes related to this incident. For more information, see Danner 2004.

4. I elaborate on the idea of everyday pornography in Caputi 2004c and an educational documentary, *The Pornography of Everyday Life* distributed by Berkeley Media ([www.berkeleymedia.com](http://www.berkeleymedia.com)) where I explore in greater detail the correspon-

The anti-pornography work of Andrea Dworkin and Catharine MacKinnon (1988) suggests that Abu Ghraib is no anomaly, for, in their view, sexist cultures inherently sexualize and gender domination. Dworkin's and MacKinnon's objection to commercial pornography is not its offense to conventional morality (which absurdly deems sex itself to be obscene or 'dirty'). Rather, the problem is pornography's impediment to equality. In their view, not all sexual materials constitute pornography, but only those (now in the majority) that depict 'the graphic, sexually explicit subordination', dehumanization, violation, and degradation of women, or of men, transsexuals, or children used in the place of women. As gender roles are played out, the dominant role is the masculine one, even when it is assumed by, or forced onto, a woman, while the subordinated position is feminine, even when assumed by, or forced onto, a man.<sup>5</sup>

Pornography in this way can be understood as a 'habit of thinking this is a relation of dominance and submission' (Williams 1995: 123), a kind of worldview. Consider the ways that such pornographic notions of sex and gender are inherent in what seems to be the very antithesis of pornography—patriarchal religion. Religiously sanctioned gender roles also mandate female submission, 'gracious' (as the Southern Baptists put it) or otherwise to male authority. This becomes explicit in the bestselling Christian-oriented marriage how-to book, *The Surrendered Wife*, which advises 'High gender contrast in a marriage is what makes things exciting in the bedroom' (Doyle 2001: 200).

This same pornographic sexuality is tapped to support colonial ventures and genocides that rely upon justifying narratives featuring a supposedly masculine, pure, and advanced civilization dominating a supposedly feminine, dirty, and savage one, for example the genocide

dences between the Abu Ghraib torture and its close relationship to depictions in mainstream imagery.

5. Clearly, women or lower status men sometimes willingly assume this role, but sometimes they are coerced. One of the iconic images from Abu Ghraib shows Lynndie England dragging a naked Iraqi man on a leash. Charles Graner, apparently the ringleader at Abu Ghraib, was England's lover at the time. He sent this picture to friends, telling them, 'Look what I made Lynndie do'. The paradigm for the situation where men are forced into a feminine role is prison rape, where the raped man becomes the 'girl' or 'bitch'. For elaboration, see Gilligan (1996). Although I do not have the space to discuss it here, the issue of what would constitute a radical sexuality, challenging conventional gender roles as well as oppressive power relations, is widely debated. Some claim that the deliberate reversal of roles and conscious staging of power-inflected sexual activity can work to subvert traditional relations and power structures. Others claim that any eroticization of domination supports the status quo.

orchestrated by Europeans and European-Americans against Native Americans (Smith 2005). Paula Gunn Allen (1986: 3) points out that the 'physical and culture genocide of American Indian tribes is and was mostly about patriarchal fear of gynocracy (egalitarian and woman-centered cultures), which was misnamed as 'savagery'.

Pornographic sexuality also is employed to fuel technological abuses of the elements and of the Earth. Carolyn Merchant (1980) has shown that the language of the seventeenth-century scientific revolution was inherently sexually violent, as revealed through its characteristic metaphors of 'mastering', 'disrobing', and 'penetrating' nature as a female form, ones that continue through this day, particularly evident in nuclear history and metaphor (Caputi 1993).

Louis Ernest Barrias' classic sculpture, 'Nature Revealed before Science' (1899), shows a desirable woman stripping to reveal her 'mysteries' to male-identified science. There are alternative paradigms to this kind of voyeuristic and controlling knowing (for example, knowledge as intimacy, knowledge as respectful communication). But for patriarchal epistemologies, as Catharine MacKinnon argues, (sexist) 'sexual metaphors for knowledge are no coincidence... Feminists are beginning to understand that to know has meant to fuck' (1983: 636). Similarly, to possess has meant to fuck and to conquer has meant to fuck—hence the 'sexiness' of excess and war.

### *Transgression: Exceeding Limits*

*'Stick It Where the Hell You Like'*

—headline of a 1995 ad for an SUV, featuring a stick-on replica of the vehicle that viewers can apply to a picture of a mountain wilderness, 'sticking it to' the Earth

*Our mission—to boldly go where no man has gone before.*

—from the original *Star Trek*

*Love's Baby Soft: Because Innocence is Sexier than You Think.*

—headline of a 1976 ad for cosmetics, showing a little girl made up to look like an adult seductress

The pursuit of excess, as well as conquest, necessarily involves a refusal to observe limits or taboos. It revels in going where one is not invited, sometimes made more exciting because no one has been there before (so-called 'virgin' territory). Overkill invariably also involves the violation of life-preservative taboos, molesting what should be left alone, staking a claim to what is unownable—forces of nature, land, animal beings, another human being. (In a green way of thinking, of course, the only



thing we ever can own is our *own* self, and the *properties* particular to that self.)

Ojibway theology/philosophy, embedded in oral tradition, insightfully warns against the addictive horrors of taboo violation and excess in the cautionary tales of the Weendigo. These cannibals eat human flesh, which causes them to grow ever larger and then need even more food. He or she is perpetually ravenous, always needing to consume more and more (Johnston 1995: 247).

Excess, taking more than one needs, also entails acquiring, through a variety of means, including seizure (the root word for *rape*), what rightfully belong to others. One culture's wealth or excess, Buddhist teacher Thich Nhat Hanh (1988) asks us to realize, actually is made up of another's poverty or deprivation.

Throughout advertising there is a recurring endorsement of various forms of excessive and obsessive appetite as well as taboo violation. Luxury auto makers rhetorically query: 'Is style seductive? Power intoxicating?... Technology addictive?' Potential buyers of cars as well as numerous other products are urged to succumb to 'temptation'. Sexy devils, usually female but sometimes male, entice us into indulging in sweets and liquors. Of course, commercial manipulation of guilt, shame, pleasure, and desire is made that much easier when the dominant moralistic tradition has so fundamentally intertwined sin with sex.

In the religious traditions based in the story of Adam and Eve, sexuality itself, particularly autonomous female and non-procreative sexuality, is the archetypal forbidden fruit. Biblical scholars may dispute this, pointing to disobedience as the central transgression but it does not really matter. In the popular moralism associated with patriarchal religions, sex is the culprit and Eve the villain. But in pre-patriarchal traditions, the elements of the story assemble differently. The garden is the dwelling place of the serpent, the original bi-sexual God/dess, and avatar of the Life force, the material holiness of nature, Eros, and soul (Chevalier and Gheerbrant 1994: 845). The subsequent patriarchal linking of the serpent and sexuality with sin amounts, then, 'to a refusal to affirm life' (Campbell 1988: 47).

This refusal, and its continuing repercussions, has everything to do with how excess becomes sexy and sustainability boring. In a consumer culture, the repressed erotic can be channeled into the addictive thrills of getting, spending, owning, and overpowering. And when sex is associated with the forbidden, doing something forbidden often acquires an erotic charge. Acts that an egalitarian culture really needs to be tabooed, including rape and murder, can become sexually compelling in ways they otherwise might not have been – witness the hero stature accorded

serial sex killers, both real and fictional (from Jack the Ripper to Hannibal Lector [Caputi 1987]). Similarly, the acts that a sustainable culture really needs to be tabooed, like avaricious acquisition, appropriation of others' resources, and violation of others' boundaries, also become the stuff not of monster but of hero tales. Ojibway stories about the monstrous Weendigo are cautionary and tragic. Nobody in their right mind would want to be one. But in the culture that celebrates excess (while stigmatizing, exploiting, and punishing those it impoverishes) who would not want to be a millionaire?

### *Gynocide and Geocide*

*Gynocide*: the fundamental intent of global patriarchy: planned, institutionalized spiritual and bodily destruction of women...calculated to bring about the destruction of women as a political and cultural force...the master model of genocide, paradigm for the systematic destruction of any racial, political, or cultural group (Daly with Caputi 1987: 77).

We have a moral sense of suicide, homicide, and genocide, but no moral sense of biocide or geocide, the killing of the life systems themselves and even the killing of the Earth (Thomas Berry, in Walljasper and Spayde 2001: 7).

Throughout patriarchal history, *gynocide* historically has taken such forms as sexual slavery, rape, incest, battery, sex-selective abortion, infanticide, and neglect, sexual mutilation, sexual murder, honor killings, and witch-crazes. Feminist theologian Mary Daly (1978) finds a divine role model for all of this, arguing that the defining moment of patriarchal myth is an act of *gynocide*—Goddess murder—most famously in the Sumerian 'creation' narrative, where the younger god Marduk slays and dismembers the original mother or matrix, the dragon Goddess Tiamat. This is, moreover, an explicitly *sexual* murder. One ancient text refers to 'Marduk defeating Tiamat with his penis' (Marcus 1996: 50), as he forces an 'evil wind' into her open 'mouth' and finally her 'heart' (both of which are common symbols for the vulva). Afterwards, he forms the world from Tiamat's split body. Rosemary Radford Ruether interprets the myth: 'She can be used as matter only by being killed...making her life-giving body into "stuff" possessed and controlled by the architect of a male-defined cosmos' (2004: 391).

Arguably, this myth and other similar ones speak to the establishment of patriarchal systems and the destruction of previous social organizations and belief systems that respected female divinity and what she represented. In order for the supreme all-male God to be credible, the sexual, earthy, elemental, female, and often intersexual or bi-sexual

God/dess was demonized, turned into a symbol of evil as well as an obscenity (Caputi 2004d). Even today, this mythic moment of Goddess murder is replayed in a sculpture in front of the United Nations building in New York City, showing a knight slaying a dragon. The sculpture is titled, 'Good Defeats Evil'. Within this myth we still can discern two key patriarchal scripts: holy war against a demonized other; and the reduction of others (land, elements, and all things, animate and inanimate, natural, and man-made) to just 'stuff', something to acquire, possess, control, and, finally, disrespectfully discard.

This mythic moment of destruction of the feminine, according to feminist psychoanalytic theory, is not confined to the ancient past, but also is reenacted every day in the processes of (patriarchal) gender development, in a context where men and women are defined as opposites. Nancy Chodorow (1978) stresses the formation of conventional masculine identity in enmity to the feminine. To attain masculinity, male infants need to separate from the mother and prevent any regression to the former state of unity by maintaining rigid ego boundaries and developing a profound sense of discontinuous, non-relational being. This pattern (which may characterize only a particular patriarchal consciousness) suggests that the 'dragon' being slain is all of the 'feminine' traits that patriarchal men experience but must deny, disown, and project onto others in order to be and remain 'men'. As well, the female body (and even aspects of the male body, including the soft penis) come to signify the threat of uncontrollable nature, the confluence of life and death, the originating 'slime' or 'dirt', the dark mysterious sexual source from which we all emerge and to which we all return. As such, the prescribed work of patriarchally identified men's lives is a perpetual separation from, controlling and even destruction of what is characterized as feminine. This process targets not only women but also what is understood as Nature. In this way, gynocide becomes the master model for not only the 'systematic destruction of other racial, political, or cultural groups', but also for the systematic destruction of the environment.

During an early articulation of contemporary environmentalism, protesters seeking to preserve the 'People's Park' in Berkeley California claimed that the University of California at Berkeley was 'raping' and 'fucking with' the land, the Earth or Nature as 'mother' (Kolodny 1975: 1). Rape, if not outright sexual mutilation and murder, have long been a common popular metaphor for environmental devastations. One of the best-known of these is the naming of the mad military man, who engineers world nuclear destruction in Stanley Kubrick's *Dr Strangelove* (1963), as General Jack D. Ripper. Regardless of individual belief systems

or politics, it is hard to imagine that anyone has any trouble comprehending these gynocidal metaphors.

*Nature* is derived from the Latin *nasci*, the past participle of *natus* ('to be born'). In many sacred traditions, ancient and modern, 'the Mysterious Origin', the source or force that gives birth to all life, is understood as sexual, as a 'Primal Female' (Lao Tzu in Gottlieb 2004: 73), who is also implicitly male (since she is the origin of all life, including male life).<sup>6</sup> There really is no need for male humans to separate from this kind of Mother in order to be men.

This understanding of divinity is very different from the transcendent male deity who makes humans (really men) in his image, but resides far away in heaven. In *The Religion of Technology*, David Noble (1999) argues that actually it is this more recent conception of God that has enabled the development of masculinist and environmentally destructive technologies, promising to free men from the mortal prisons of their bodies and make them omnipotent, immortal, and perfect, just like the God they worship. Again, this can be interpreted as a desperate attempt to escape from the feminine, the body, the Earth, and even, strangely enough, from sex. But in an alternative cosmology—a green cosmology and consciousness based in immanence as well as transcendence, holism, and the holiness of matter—the female, the body, nature, dirt/earth, and sexuality are not sinful, but sacred, and the sacred is everyday, not exceptional.

In the patriarchal world, bodies, particularly feminine bodies, are mostly treated as *sacred* in the sense of something that is *sacrificed*, offered up to the God(s) of speed, quantity, excess, quick and easy profit, and, most of all, domineering power. Monica Sjöö and Barbara Mor (1991: 411) suggest that violence against women is a kind of ritual reenactment of violence against the Earth:

What can be done, under patriarchy, to one female body can be done,  
under world patriarchy, to the entire body of earth. The pornographic

6. This is most exquisitely expressed in the Tao Te Ching by Lao Tzu:  
The subtle essence of the universe is eternal.  
It is like an unfailing fountain of life which  
Flows forever in a vast and profound valley.  
It is called the Primal Female, the Mysterious Origin.  
The operation of the opening and closing of the subtle Gate of the Origin performs  
The Mystical Intercourse of the universe.  
The Mystical Intercourse brings forth all things  
From the unseen sphere into the realm of the manifest.  
The Mystical Intercourse of yin and yang  
Is the root of universal life.  
Its creativity and effectiveness are boundless (in Gottlieb 2004: 74).

images of women trussed up in chains and barbed wire, of female flesh bruised and bloodied and beaten raw, are really our species' maps of the mutilated earth...pollution...exterminations of vast numbers of animals and humans, of jungles and forests and grasslands...for power and profit.

Of course, the same is true of the torture, enslavement and genocide directed by self-nominated 'civilizers' and 'masters' against those they stigmatize as degenerate, savage, dirty, feminine, and effeminate (Dijkstra 1996). And the same is true of the sacrificed male bodies, those bodies feminized and abused in military and civilian prisons, in predatory sex crimes, in pornography, and even in the sacred imagery of the tortured body of Christ.

In respectful response to Thomas Berry, those of us committed to furthering our own and others' moral sense of, and resistance to, biocide and genocide, must simultaneously commit ourselves to a moral sense of, and resistance to, gynocide. In so doing, we participate in an ongoing redefinition of both power and sex, (re)establishing the erotic value of equality, sustainability, and peace.

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